



A FREE GUIDE FROM MARCELO MARQUES COACHING

5 Steps to Rebuild Your Life After Cancer

*A practical and honest guide to navigating the
emotional journey of remission — from someone who
has been there.*

BY **MARCELO MARQUES**
RESILIENCE & REMISSION COACH · CANCER SURVIVOR

Please read before continuing:

This guide is a **coaching resource**, not medical advice. It is not a substitute for professional medical or psychological support. The content reflects the author's personal experience as a cancer survivor and his coaching framework — it is not a clinical or therapeutic programme.

If you have concerns about your physical health or mental wellbeing, please speak to your GP or a qualified healthcare professional.

For additional support, the following organisations can help:

 **Macmillan Cancer Support** — macmillan.org.uk | 0808 808 00 00 (free, 7 days a week)

 **Cancer Research UK** — cancerresearchuk.org

 **NHS** — nhs.uk

 **Maggie's Centres** — maggies.org

 **Samaritans** (24/7 emotional support) — samaritans.org | 116 123

A Letter to You, Before We Begin

If you are reading this, you have been through something that most people will never fully understand. You have faced a cancer diagnosis, endured treatment, and come out the other side.

That takes a kind of strength that is difficult to put into words.

And yet — here is what I know from my own experience as a cancer survivor, and from working with people in remission: **the end of treatment is not the end of the journey.** For many people, it is one of the most disorienting chapters of all.

The appointments stop. The support system that formed around your illness begins to dissolve. The people who love you breathe a sigh of relief — and expect you to feel the same.

But inside, you may be asking questions you do not quite know how to voice:

"Why don't I feel the relief everyone expected me to feel?"

"Who am I now — after everything that has changed?"

"How do I build a life that actually feels worth living?"

This guide will not answer those questions for you. Only you can do that.

What it will do is give you a framework — five honest, practical steps — to help you begin moving forward. Not back to who you were before. *Forward, into who you are becoming.*

You deserve a full life. Not just a grateful one. Not just a careful one. A full one.

Let us begin.

With warmth,

Marcelo Marques

Resilience & Remission Coach · Cancer Survivor

STEP ONE



Allow Yourself to Feel What You Actually Feel

The first and most important step is also the most overlooked: **stop performing.**

When you receive a remission diagnosis, the world around you celebrates. And you want to celebrate too. But if what you actually feel is numbness, fear, emptiness, or confusion — those feelings are just as valid as the relief everyone expects you to feel.

Many survivors spend enormous energy managing other people's emotions — reassuring their family, performing gratitude, saying "I'm fine" when they are not. This is an act of love. But it comes at a cost.

The cost is connection — with yourself, and with the people around you.

You cannot build a genuine life on a foundation of feelings you are pretending not to have. The path forward begins with honesty — starting with yourself.

What this looks like in practice: Give yourself permission, even just for 10 minutes a day, to feel what you actually feel. Journal it. Say it out loud to yourself. You do not have to share it with anyone. But stop hiding it from yourself.

This is not wallowing. This is the foundation of everything that follows.

♥ REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What am I actually feeling right now — underneath the version I show to others?

What emotions have I been avoiding or suppressing since my diagnosis?

What would I say if I knew nobody would worry about me?

STEP TWO

2

Understand the Fear — and Learn to Live Alongside It

One of the most universal experiences of remission is fear. Not the acute terror of diagnosis — but a quieter, more persistent fear that settles in afterwards.

The fear that it will come back.

Every headache becomes a question. Every scan becomes weeks of held breath. Your body — which was once simply yours — has become something you no longer fully trust.

This is known as fear of recurrence, and research consistently shows it is experienced by a significant proportion of cancer survivors. You are not alone in this. And you are not being irrational.

The goal is not to eliminate the fear. For most people, it does not disappear entirely. The goal is to build a life so intentional and so full that the fear no longer runs it.

What this looks like in practice: Notice when the fear arrives — and name it. "This is fear of recurrence. It is real, but it is not a fact." Then redirect your attention to something concrete and present. Over time, this builds genuine resilience — not armour, but inner steadiness.

Working with a coach or therapist can be invaluable here. Having a space to voice the fear, without worrying about how it lands on the people you love, changes everything.

When does the fear of recurrence feel most overwhelming? What triggers it?

What do I do when the fear arrives — and does it help?

What would it feel like to live alongside the fear rather than fighting it?

STEP THREE



Rebuild Your Identity on Your Own Terms

Cancer gives you an identity — patient, fighter, survivor. Your whole world organises itself around your illness. And then, when treatment ends, there can be a strange vacuum.

Who am I now?

This question is at the heart of the remission journey — and it is one of the least talked about. From the outside, you look fine. Inside, you are quietly trying to figure out who you are on the other side of the hardest thing you have ever been through.

Here is what I want you to know: you cannot go back to who you were before. Too much has changed. But that is not a loss. It is an invitation.

The question is not "who was I?" It is "who do I want to become?" That is a question worth sitting with — and worth building an answer to, deliberately and on your own terms.

What this looks like in practice: Make a list of values that feel true to you *now* — not before cancer, not what others expect of you, but what genuinely matters to you today. Use these as the foundation of your choices going forward: how you spend your time, what you say yes and no to, what kind of relationships you invest in.

♥ REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What parts of my old identity still feel true — and what no longer fits?

What matters to me now that did not matter — or not as much — before?

If I could describe the person I am becoming in three words, what would they be?

STEP FOUR

4

Reconnect — With People, Purpose, and Your Body

After illness, reconnection is both necessary and difficult. Relationships may have been strained by the weight of your treatment. Your sense of purpose may feel unclear. And your relationship with your own body — prodded, scanned, and treated — may feel distant or mistrustful.

Reconnection is not a single event. It is a practice, built from small moments.

With people: Choose one relationship that matters to you and invest in it genuinely this week. Not a check-in — a real conversation. Let someone in, even just a little.

With purpose: Ask yourself: what activity, when I do it, makes me forget to check the time? Start there. Purpose does not always announce itself grandly — it often begins as a quiet pull.

With your body: your body has been through something enormous. It deserves gentleness — not punishment, not pushing through, but genuine care. One walk. One meal cooked with attention. One moment of stillness. Start small.

A note on returning to work: Many survivors find this one of the hardest transitions. If this is you — know that feeling lost, exhausted, or like you have to prove yourself all over again is completely normal. It does not mean something is wrong with you. It means you are human, and you have been through something significant.

Which relationships in my life feel genuinely nourishing — and which feel draining?

What activities make me feel most like myself?

What is one small thing I can do this week to be kinder to my body?

STEP FIVE

5

Design Your Fuller Life — Not Just Your Recovery

This is the step that changes everything.

Remission is not just the end of something. It is the beginning of something. And you are allowed — truly, genuinely allowed — to want more from that beginning than simply surviving.

You are allowed to want joy. Purpose. Deep relationships. Work that means something. Mornings that feel worth getting up for.

I call this building your **Fuller Life**. Not a survival kit — you have already survived. This is about building a life that is genuinely, unapologetically yours.

A Fuller Life is not a perfect life. It is not an easy life. It is a life that is more honest, more intentional, and more truly yours than the one you had before. That is what I believe is possible for you.

What this looks like in practice: Write down one vision for your life 12 months from now. Not a list of tasks — a picture. Where are you? Who are you with? How do you feel when you wake up in the morning? What are you doing that matters?

That vision becomes your compass. Every decision — how you spend your time, what you invest your energy in, what you say yes and no to — can be measured against it.

You do not have to figure this out alone. In fact, you will get there faster with support.

What does a genuinely full life look like for me — not for anyone else, for me?

What am I waiting for permission to want?

What is one step I could take this week towards that vision?

You Don't Have to Do This Alone

These five steps are a beginning. A framework to help you make sense of where you are and where you want to go.

But reading about a journey and walking it are two different things. Real change happens in conversation — in the space where you can be honest about what you are going through, without performing strength or managing someone else's feelings.

That is what coaching provides.

My name is Marcelo Marques. I am a resilience and remission coach based in London — and a cancer survivor. I work with people who are navigating life after cancer and want to build something genuinely meaningful on the other side of it.

I offer a free 30-minute discovery call — no obligation, no sales pitch. Just an honest conversation about where you are and whether coaching might help.

Book Your Free Discovery Call

A 30-minute conversation. No pressure. Just an honest talk about where you are and what might help.

 marcelomarquescoaching.com/book-now

 marcelomarquescoaching@gmail.com

 [@marcelomcoaching](https://www.instagram.com/marcelomcoaching)

"The rest is still unwritten — and it belongs to you."

FURTHER SUPPORT & RESOURCES

 **Macmillan Cancer Support** — macmillan.org.uk | 0808 808 00 00

 **Cancer Research UK** — cancerresearchuk.org

 **NHS** — nhs.uk

 **Maggie's Centres** — maggies.org

 **Samaritans** (24/7 emotional support) — samaritans.org | 116 123

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